

INDIA TODAY

www.indiatoday.com

Editor-in-Chief: Aroon Purie
Chief Executive Officer: Ashish Bagga

Editor: Prabhu Chawla

Managing Editors: Raj Chengappa, Dilip Bobb, Shankar Aiyar

Executive Editors: Kaveree Bamzai, S. Prasannarajan

Deputy Editors: Farzand Ahmed, Damayanti Datta, S. Kalidas, Sharda Ugra

Senior Editors: Ashok K. Damodaran, Dwaipayan Bose, Amarnath K. Menon (Hyderabad)

Photo Editor: Bandeep Singh

Art Editor: Sapna Kapoor

Associate Editors: Saurabh Shukla, Malini Bhupta (Mumbai),
Uday Mahurkar (Ahmedabad)

Assistant Editors: S. Sahaya Ranjit, Priya Sahgal, Sandeep Unnithan,
Subhash Mishra (Lucknow), Ramesh Vinayak (Chandigarh)

Special Correspondents: Kimi Dangor (Mumbai), Rohit Parihar (Jaipur),
Neeraj Mishra (Delhi), Nirmala Ravindran (Bangalore),
M.G. Radhakrishnan (Thiruvananthapuram), S.S. Jeevan (Chennai)

Principal Correspondents: BANGALORE: Stephen David BIOPAL; Ambresh Mishra
DELHI: Satarupa Bhattacharjya, Supriya Dravid, Puja Mehra, Nandini Vaish

Senior Correspondents: KOLKATA: Swagata Sen MUMBAI: Aditi Pai, Prerana Thakurdesai

Copy Desk: Shalini S. Sharma (Assistant Editor), Paramita Chatterjee,
Kaushik Deka, Sharmila Dhal, Sangram Keshari Parhi,
Arundhati Pramod, Gaurav Rajkhowa, V. Shoba,
Rahul Tewari, Priya Verma, Anju Yadav

Photo Department: Hemant Chawla, Sipra Das, Yasbant Negi,
Sumeet Inder Singh, Ishan Tankha, Ravi Sahani, Gireesh G.V. (Bangalore),
Shailesh Raval (Ahmedabad), Bhaskar Paul, H.K. Rajashekar (Chennai),
Rashmi Hajela (Chief Photo Researcher)

Infographics and Illustrations: Saurabh Singh

Art Department: Madhu Bhaskar, Vandana Nayar (Deputy Art Directors),
Rasmi Ajmani, Ranjita Bhattacharjya, Pushvinder Kaur, Jyoti Singh

Production Department: Surinder Hastu (Chief of Production),
Harish Aggarwal, Naveen Gupta

Associate Publishers: Malcolm D. Mistry (Impact)
Umesh Kumar (Marketing)

IMPACT TEAM

Director (Impact): Manoj Sharma

Senior General Manager: Anil Fernandes (West & South)

Head (Impact): Ashok Bindra (North)

General Managers: Kaustav Chatterjee (East),
Carl Avari (Bangalore)

Assistant General Manager: V. Somasundaram (Chennai)

Consumer Marketing Services: Poonam Sangha, Senior General Manager

Newsstand Sales: Vivek Gaur, Executive Director
D.V.S. Rama Rao, Senior General Manager (National Sales)
C.V. Vaidyalingham, Senior General Manager (South)

Vinod Das, Deputy General Manager (North)
Rajesh Menon, Deputy General Manager (West)
Rajeev Gandhi, Deputy Regional Manager (East)

OPERATIONS: S. Sridhar, General Manager



Volume XXXII Number 23; For the week June 5-11, 2007, released on June 4

• Editorial Office Living Media India Ltd. F-14/15, Connaught Place New Delhi 110001; Phones: 23315801-4;

• Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, A-61, Sector-57, Noida (UP) 201301;

Phones: (95120) 2479900 from Delhi and Faridabad; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India; Toll-free number:

1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines) and 120 2479900 (Monday-Friday, 10 am-6 pm); Fax: (0120) 4078080;

e-mail: arecare@indiatoday.com; Mumbai: 022-2444423-6; Fax: 244-44358 • Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to
General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, 201 Competent House, F-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place,

New Delhi • Regd. Office: K-9 Connaught Circus, New Delhi 110001 • Impact Offices: Trade Centre, 2nd Floor,

Kamala City, Senapati Bagat Marg, Lower Ground, Mumbai 400013; Phone: 24983355; Fax: 24982266 • Hamilton

House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23352233; Fax: 23327330 • 99-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai,

2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai 600 004; Phones: 28478526-41; Telex: 041-6177 Int'l; Fax: 28472178; Cable:

Livmedia Chennai • 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones:

22212448, 22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218355; Cable: Livmedia, Bangalore • 52, Jawaharal Nehru Road,

4th Floor, Kolkata-700071; Phones: 22825398; Fax: 22827254; Cable: Livmedia, Kolkata • G-3-885/7/B,

Somajiguda, Hyderabad-500082; Phone: 23401657, 23406479, 23410100, 23402481, 23410982, 23411498;

Fax: 23403484 • 39/1045, Karakatt Road, Kanchi 682016; Phones: 2377057, 2377058; Fax: 2377059

• 2C, "Suryarath Bldg", 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panvel, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006;

Phone: 26560393, 26560929; Fax: 26565293

• Copyright Living Media India Ltd. All rights reserved throughout the world. Reproduction in any manner is prohibited. Printed and published by Ashish Bagga on behalf of Living Media India Ltd. Printed at Thomson Press India Ltd., 18-35 Milestone, Delhi Mathura Road, Faridabad-121007 (Haryana), at Thomson Press India Ltd., A-9, Industrial Complex, Maraimalai Nagar, District Kanchipuram-603209 (Tamil Nadu), and at Thomson Press India Ltd., Plot No. 5-5A, TTC Industrial Area, Thane, Belapur Road, Airoli, Navi Mumbai-400708 (Maharashtra).

Published at K-9, Connaught Circus, New Delhi-110001

• India Today does not take responsibility for returning unsolicited publication material

All disputes are subject to the exclusive jurisdiction of competent courts and forums in Delhi/New Delhi only

While we are all cheering India's unprecedented growth of over 9 per cent, we often forget a looming crisis below all this optimism. The simple fact is that India's economy is terribly skewed. We still have 68 per cent of our workforce in farming though agriculture's contribution to GDP has dropped from 38 per cent in 1975 to 19 per cent now. It is a serious structural crisis which gets lost in the roar of our self-congratulation. The country only wakes up to this when food prices start rising in the shops. The much touted Green Revolution of the mid-1960's has definitely gone brown.

To top it all, agricultural growth has hit a plateau of 1.8 per cent and a country that boasted of producing enough food to feed its people is now importing food grains again. We require 210 million tons of grain but produce 200 million, resulting in expected import this year of 10 million tons. Importing food grain is not bad in itself. Many countries do it but then what are 739 million people in India doing on our farms?

The reason for this crisis is that there have been no new breakthroughs or investment in seed technology to improve farm yields. We are currently witnessing the worst decade for Indian agriculture since Independence.

Agriculture faces a crisis of land as the spread of cultivable land for food grains has remained stagnant at 120 million hectares. The profitability from this land has not increased either as land holdings have become smaller and investment is negligible. The sector is also reeling under a crisis of water as it remains heavily dependent on monsoons. There is a disincentive amongst the younger rural people to get involved in agriculture, which appears to promise only an uncertain livelihood and crippling debt. A decade more of the same criminal neglect and India's myth of food grain self-sufficiency will be well and truly busted.

Our cover story has been put together by Managing Editor Raj Chengappa who spoke to experts and policy analysts to understand the phenomenon. We asked correspondents in five states to give us an accurate picture of the Indian agriculturist today.

This dismal state of agriculture calls for a questioning of preconceived notions and tough decisions. In a globalised world where India has emerged as a major economic player, we need to be confident enough to re-examine the definition of 'self-sufficiency' and ensure it has not become another word for poor use of available resources.

Indian agriculture needs diversification and innovative thinking. It needs to find jobs for those who are grossly under-employed, to discover and implement a market approach to agriculture. It is said that India lives in its villages. But those villagers need to live as well as the rest of India for our growth to be truly meaningful.

(Aroon Purie)